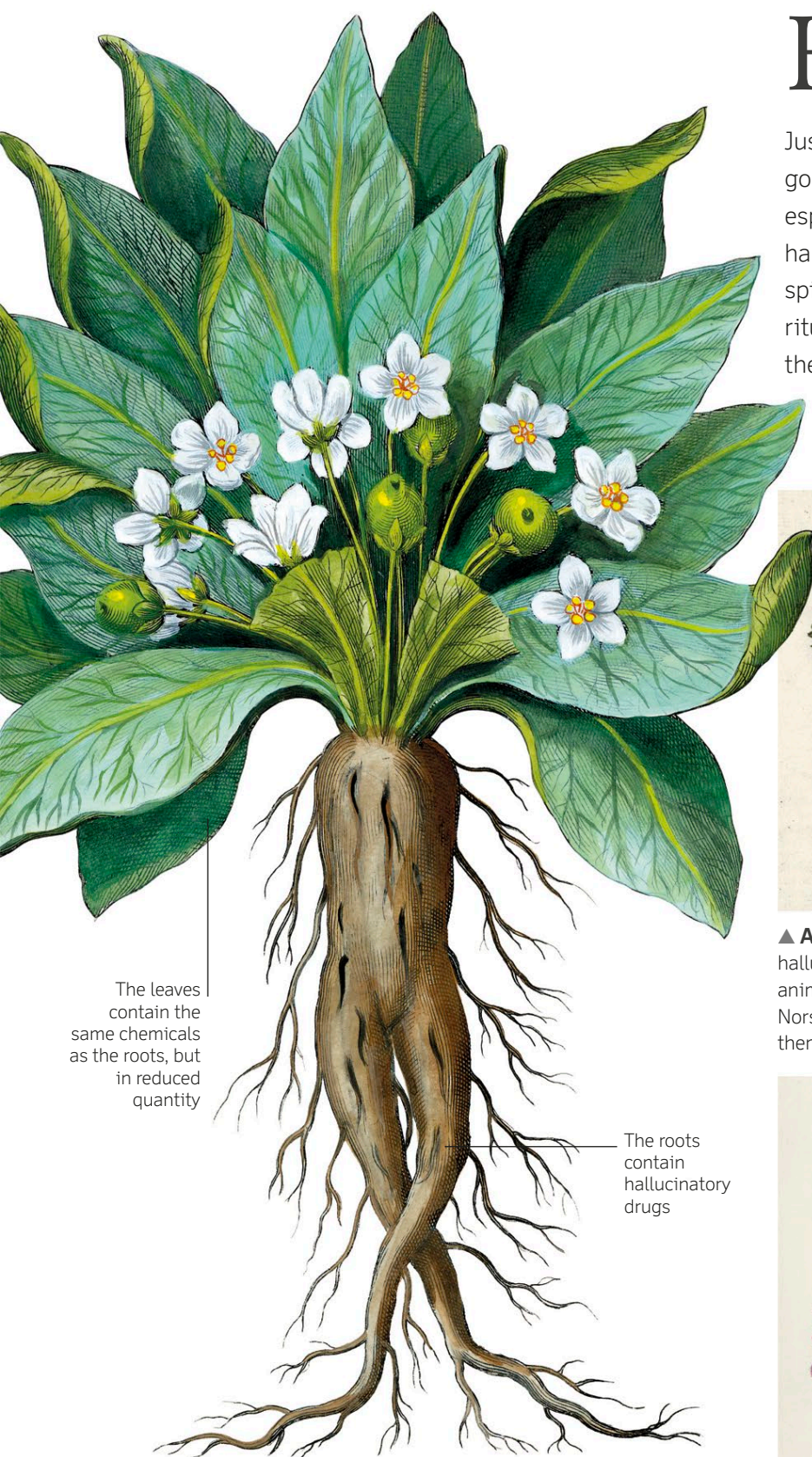


Harmful plants

Just as some plants have been, and still are, used for healing and good magic, so others have long had more sinister associations, especially those that are deadly poisonous. Certain plants contain hallucinogens, used to induce trances and visions, to ward off evil spirits or, in the case of mandrake root, to feature in black magic rituals. In the past, some plants had such a bad reputation that they were believed to bring evil just by growing near the home, particularly if they happened to bloom out of season.



The leaves contain the same chemicals as the roots, but in reduced quantity

The roots contain hallucinatory drugs

▲ **Mandrake** is the most feared of plants and owes its reputation to its man-shaped roots, which, when pulled from the ground, allegedly uttered a deadly shriek. However, sucking a mandrake leaf for a month was said to give a wizard the power to change into an animal.



▲ **Aconite** (wolfsbane) can cause hallucinations of shape-shifting into an animal and it was said to be taken by Norse Berserker warriors to transform themselves into werewolves for battle.



▲ **Elder trees** are rich in healing qualities but they are also the “death tree” because they seem to regenerate from dead branches. Cutting one down is said to release a malevolent spirit.



▲ **Belladonna** (deadly nightshade) is poisonous and has hallucinogenic properties. Witches reportedly rubbed the plant into their thighs to enable them to fly on broomsticks.



▲ **Blackthorn** is thought of as a plant of ill omen. Yet magically, it is used to protect against evil, dispel negativity and toxins, and help people confront their inner demons.